

session-handoff

Ends every working session with a document the next session reads first — so it resumes your work without re-deriving decisions, re-checking state, or repeating dead ends.

Version 0.4.1**License** MIT**Repository** github.com/anish00700/claude-session-handoff

1 The problem it solves

Long sessions end one of two ways: you run `/clear`, or the context window quietly fills up. Either way the next session starts blind. It re-reads files you already read, re-asks questions you already answered, and — the expensive one — sometimes retries the exact approach that failed three hours ago.

A handoff file fixes that, but only if it records what a repository *cannot*: intent, rejected options, decisions made out loud, and the tool quirks you discovered the hard way. Your commit history already covers the rest.

This plugin adds one skill that writes and maintains that file. It runs the git commands to verify state rather than trusting recall, records failed attempts alongside the reason they failed, and names what is deliberately *not* done — the three things that save the most time downstream.

2 Before you start

Claude Code	Any version with plugin support. Check with <code>claude --version</code> .
Git	The skill runs <code>git status</code> , <code>git log</code> , and <code>git worktree list</code> to verify state. It works outside a repository, with less to go on.
python3	Used by the plugin's hooks. If it is missing the hooks no-op silently — the skill still works, you just lose the automatic loading.
GitHub access	Only to fetch the marketplace, once. The repository is public — no token or SSH key needed.

3 Install

Two commands, run from anywhere. Both are one-time.

1 Add the marketplace

This registers where the plugin lives. It clones the repository into your local plugin cache.

```
$ claude plugin marketplace add anish00700/claude-session-handoff

Adding marketplace...
Cloning repository, validating marketplace...
✓ Successfully added marketplace: claude-session-handoff
```

2 Install the plugin

The `@` suffix names the marketplace to install from. It is required — without it, Claude Code searches every marketplace you have registered.

```
$ claude plugin install session-handoff@claude-session-handoff
```

```
✓ Successfully installed plugin: session-handoff@claude-session-handoff (scope: user)
```

Scope: user means it is available in every project on your machine, not just the current one. That is the right default for this plugin — a handoff is useful in any repository.

Verify

```
$ claude plugin list
```

```
Installed plugins:
```

```
› session-handoff@claude-session-handoff
  Version: 0.4.1
  Scope: user
  Status: ✓ enabled
```

Restart your session

Skills load at session start. If you installed while a session was running, start a new one before the skill becomes available.

4 Using it

There is nothing to configure and no command to memorise. The skill activates on its own when a session is winding down — say any of these in plain language:

wrap up

write the handoff

hand this off

I'm about to clear

save state

update the handoff

It also triggers when your context window is running low, which is the case that matters most — that is precisely when work is about to be lost and you are least likely to remember to ask.

Installed skills also appear in the slash-command list. Run `/help` in a session to see the exact name on your setup.

What happens

The skill reads any existing handoff first, runs `git` and `gh` commands to confirm the real state, then writes `SESSION_HANDOFF.md` to the directory you are working in. On later sessions it **replaces** that file rather than appending — carrying forward what is still open and dropping what got resolved. Handoffs never stack up.

It is not committed automatically
The file is written to disk and left untracked. Commit it if your team should see it, or add it to `.gitignore` if it is just for you.

It loads itself back, automatically

Claude Code auto-loads `CLAUDE.md` but never `SESSION_HANDOFF.md`. The plugin ships hooks that close the gap without you doing anything: at session start and after a compaction, the handoff for your working directory is injected straight into context. Other handoffs elsewhere in the repository are listed by path only, so a large repo costs a line rather than a page.

When a handoff is written, a `CLAUDE.md` pointer appears beside it — and if the handoff sits in a subdirectory, a second pointer is added to the **repository root** `CLAUDE.md` naming the relative path. Without that, a session started at the root would never learn the handoff exists. Everything is idempotent, and a silent no-op when there is no handoff.

What gets injected, and how far it is trusted

Putting a file into the model's context with no user action is a real trust decision, so the hook makes it explicitly rather than by accident.

LIMIT	WHY IT EXISTS
50 KB cap	A handoff is normally a few kilobytes, so anything past the cap is truncated with a note. Without a limit an oversized file — a pasted log dump is enough — would consume the context window before you had typed anything, and do it invisibly.
A committed handoff is treated as untrusted	If <code>SESSION_HANDOFF.md</code> is tracked in git, it came with the repository and was written by whoever wrote the repository, who is not necessarily you. Tracked handoffs are framed as third-party data whose instructions carry no authority. An <i>untracked</i> handoff is your own working copy's, and keeps the previous-session framing.

The boundary falls out of the writing rule

A handoff is not meant to be committed — so a committed one did not come from this working copy. The skill's own convention is what makes the distinction reliable.

What it writes to your files

The plugin edits `CLAUDE.md` on your behalf. That is the point of it — a handoff nothing points to is a handoff nobody reads — but the scope is deliberately narrow.

BEHAVIOUR	DETAIL
Trigger	A <code>PostToolUse</code> hook runs after every write or edit, and exits immediately unless the file just written is named exactly <code>SESSION_HANDOFF.md</code> .
Files touched	At most two, both named <code>CLAUDE.md</code> : one beside the handoff, and — only when the handoff is in a subdirectory of a git repository — one at the repository root. Nothing else on disk is touched, and nothing is ever deleted.
How it writes	Appends a block delimited by <code><!-- session-handoff:begin --></code> and <code><!-- session-handoff:end --></code> . Your existing content is never reformatted, reordered, or removed.
If there is no <code>CLAUDE.md</code>	It creates one, with an <code># <directory name></code> heading and the pointer block. A <code>CLAUDE.md</code> holding only a pointer is the intended result.
Repeat runs	Idempotent — one block however many times it runs. The root pointer is keyed by the handoff's relative path, so several subdirectory handoffs each get their own entry.
Visibility	Every write emits a message naming each file created or updated, so it shows up in your session rather than only in <code>git status</code> .

To undo a write, delete the marked block — or the file, if the plugin created it. To stop it happening, disable or uninstall the plugin: the hook ships with it and is not separately configurable.

5 What it produces

SECTION	WHAT IT CARRIES
Header	Absolute date, what to read next, which handoff this supersedes
State in one line	Where things stand, for someone who reads nothing else
Where the work lives	Checkouts, worktrees, branches, key paths
What happened this session	Chronological — including attempts that failed, and why
Current exact state	Verified facts, marked so nobody re-checks them
Decisions already settled	Confirmed choices, marked don't-re-ask
Explicitly NOT done	Named gaps, and what is waiting on you
Operational notes	Gotchas, broken tooling, real port numbers, workarounds
Next step	The single first action, and what not to redo

Target length is 60–120 lines: short enough that the next session actually reads it before starting, long enough to carry the decisions.

What the output looks like

A fragment from the worked example bundled with the plugin. The project is invented; the shape is what matters.

SESSION_HANDOFF.md

State in one line

The Redis-backed rate limiter is written, tested, and open as a PR, but the production cutover is gated behind a flag that is still off. Work is on `feat/redis-rate-limiter`, tip `9c41f0a` — CI green, one approval, not merged.

What happened this session

2. First Lua implementation had a race — reverted. The initial script did `ZCARD` then `ZADD` as two round trips, so concurrent requests could both read a count below the limit and both admit. It passed unit tests because those exercised one goroutine at a time.

The mechanism matters: any implementation that reads the count and writes the entry in separate round trips is wrong. Don't reintroduce a "simpler" two-call version.

Explicitly NOT done / still open

Load test at 3x peak — not started. This is the merge blocker.

The production cutover itself — the team's call, not something to do proactively.

Note what the fragment does that a commit log cannot: it names the *mechanism* of a failure so nobody retries it, and it distinguishes work that is unfinished from work that is deliberately someone else's decision.

6 Maintaining the install

TASK	COMMAND
Update to the latest version	<code>claude plugin update session-handoff@claude-session-handoff</code>
Refresh the marketplace listing	<code>claude plugin marketplace update claude-session-handoff</code>
Temporarily disable	<code>claude plugin disable session-handoff@claude-session-handoff</code>
Re-enable	<code>claude plugin enable session-handoff@claude-session-handoff</code>
Remove the plugin	<code>claude plugin uninstall session-handoff@claude-session-handoff</code>
Remove the marketplace too	<code>claude plugin marketplace remove claude-session-handoff</code>

Updates require a session restart to take effect.

7 Troubleshooting

SYMPTOM	CAUSE AND FIX
The skill never triggers	Skills load at session start. Restart, then confirm with <code>claude plugin list</code> that status is enabled.
Repository not found on marketplace add	Usually a typo in the owner/repo. The correct source is <code>anish00700/claude-session-handoff</code> , and it is public — no credentials needed.
Two handoff skills appear	You have both this plugin and a local copy in <code>~/.claude/skills/</code> . Keep one: uninstall the plugin, or delete the local directory.
A project version should win	A skill at <code><repo>/~/.claude/skills/session-handoff/</code> takes precedence inside that repository. Use this to keep a project-specific example.
The handoff states things that aren't true	The skill verifies with git before writing, but it cannot verify claims about intent. Read it once and correct it — it is a normal Markdown file.

8 Customising it

The plugin is three plain Markdown files. Clone the repository, edit `skills/session-handoff/SKILL.md` to change the section list or the writing rules, and edit `reference/example.md` to swap the worked example for one from your own codebase.

A team-specific example is the single highest-value change you can make — the skill matches the tone and granularity of whatever example it is shown. If you change the section list in `SKILL.md`, update `reference/template.md` to match; they are meant to stay in lockstep.

To distribute an internal variant, drop the edited skill into your repository at `.claude/skills/session-handoff/` and commit it. Everyone who clones gets it with no install step, and it overrides the public plugin inside that repository.